Introduction

This is the story of Erich Honecker, his life and his work.

It has been nearly thirty years since he died in exile and disgrace at a small villa in Chile. However, in today's Germany, Honecker and his era are enjoying increasing popularity which, in part, comes from the trend of Ostalgie or Ostalgia – newish words which describe a feeling of longing or desire for life in the former German Democratic Republic (GDR). In recent years, long-defunct East German products like 'Softee' ice cream, malted coffee, Spreewald gherkins, sparkling wine from Freyburg, and Halloren chocolate balls have appeared on the market. Honecker postcards and t-shirts sit alongside spray-painted chunks of the Berlin Wall at most gift shops in Berlin.

Across the country, newspapers often remind readers that the former chancellor Angela Merkel grew up in the GDR and even served as a cultural official for the FDJ, Honecker's youth organisation. (Curiously, Merkel was recently allocated the former office of Margot Honecker on Wilhelm Straße, from where she now conducts her activities).

It is also common knowledge – especially since the brutal war in Ukraine – that Vladimir Putin cut his teeth in Dresden serving as a KGB officer alongside Honecker's security services during the 1980s. It was in East Germany where Putin learned about the frailty of authoritarian regimes. With the collapse of the GDR, he returned home full of a bitterness that lingers to this day.

The attractions of Erich Honecker as a biographical subject are obvious enough. At the simplest level, it is a tale of ambition told amid the background of economic depression, Nazi tyranny, global conflict and Cold War. Of all the leaders in the communist world, he was the most unexpected. Even his political master Leonid Brezhnev dithered about supporting his leadership of the GDR in 1971.